city as a space of strained coexistence and potential connection across multiple divisions.

After she returned home to New York from her first trip to Berlin in 1984, Lorde prepared poetry for publication that would ultimately appear in *Our Dead Behind Us*. She writes about this period in journal entries included in *A Burst of Light* (and in other pieces in her archive, including unpublished journal entries and drafts of poems) and presents this time from late 1984 through 1986 as one of revision and continued reflection about Berlin, a city she renders in descriptions of textures, both rough and soft. She collected several poems for a preliminary collection, initially titled, "POEMS from OUT TO THE HARD ROAD."[52] Lorde published some of her poems to be later included in *Our Dead Behind Us* in journals and magazines such as *Black Scholar, Ikon,* and *Parnassus*. She submitted the book-length manuscript, with forty-three poems, to her publisher Norton no later than December 1985, and in January 1986 she received page proof. The book was published in late 1986.

Given the centrality of divided Berlin to the book's conceptualization and production, Lorde's poem "Berlin Is Hard on Colored Girls" is an integral poem through which the author highlights her experiences of Berlin in poetic complexity. According to her archive, Lorde began drafting this poem in her journal on May 8 and 9, 1984, while teaching in Berlin. The typed drafts of the poem that survive are dated February 11, March 31, and April 1, 1985.[53] At each stage, Lorde tends to her draft around choices of language and line spacing. The poem features an intermingled use of recognizable symbols and sites from both sides of Berlin, as well as coyly presented private images and memories that transcend the divided city's limits.

Scholars have suggested that Lorde represents the plight of Afro-German women in her poem. Melba Boyd, who attended Lorde's reading at West Berlin's Amerika Haus, contends that the poem "embodies [Lorde's] identification with the plight of Afro-Germans and women of color in Berlin, as 'woman' is coded as the city, with forbidden borders and American influences."[54] The "American influences" Boyd mentions should also be read to include Lorde's own experiences in Berlin. To be sure, Lorde's poetic rendering of Berlin as a "strange woman" opens the poem around notions of identity and estrangement for her observations of the city but, importantly, also about herself. The title of the poem signals the Afro-German community's strained relationship with the city, but it also deploys the term